

Pahankanuwa Sermon #7

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Cakkhumā visamānīva,

vijjamāne parakkame;

Paṇḍito jīvalokasmiṃ,

pāpāni parivajjaye.

From:

Verse 28 from the Appamādavagga (Chapter on Heedfulness) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

After attaining supreme enlightenment, when our Buddha looked at the world with His Buddha-eye, this world appeared to that Buddha-eye just like a lotus pond or a water-lily pond. In a lotus pond or a water-lily pond, some flower buds are submerged in the water, growing under the water. Some other buds have grown level with the water's surface, just barely emerging. Yet other buds have risen above the water, waiting as if for the sun to rise, standing tall and ready.

Just so, according to that simile, our Buddha understood the different levels of intelligence of beings in this world. Some people have very low saṃsāric intelligence; they live attached and deeply immersed in the world. They do not think of a next world, nor of the Nibbāna nor of ending the suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra. There are some other human beings, another group, who have the capacity to at least occasionally think about the next world and the suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra in a way that allows them to gain some understanding. There are still others who have cultivated their minds by practicing meditation

for a long time in saṃsāra. They are like those flower buds that have risen above the water, waiting for the sun to rise. As soon as the rays of the Dhamma from that sun—the Buddha-sun—fall upon them, they bloom. In the same way, human beings who possess such a refined mental continuum, who are highly developed beings, bloom just like a lotus flower or a water-lily flower when the Dhamma-rays of our Buddha fall upon them. The Dhamma-eye arises in them. Their eyes are opened.

**Although this sermon was delivered based on the Udāna Pāḷi, the story also appears with certain variations in the commentary to the Bālavagga of the Dhammapada.*

While our Buddha was residing in the Veluvana monastery in the city of Rājagaha, one day He was preaching the Dhamma to a large gathering near a street. There lived in that very city of Rājagaha a very poor leper named Suppabuddha. This man, while searching for food on that day, saw a large crowd gathered on this street. He thought, "Surely, this must be a place where food is being distributed. If I also go near this crowd, perhaps I might find some food." So, he hurried there and approached. Having arrived, he realized, "This is not a place where food is being distributed. The Blessed Gautama Ascetic is preaching the Dhamma to a crowd here. No matter, I too should listen to at least a bit of the Dhamma." Thinking so, he sat down to one side. At that moment, the Blessed One examined, scrutinized, and reflected upon the minds of that entire gathering with His Buddha-knowledge. He looked to see who among this great crowd was capable of understanding the deep Dhamma, the Dhamma of the Nibbāna which He was preaching, and who could understand it best. To that Buddha-knowledge, to that Buddha-eye, there appeared Suppabuddha the leper sitting at the edge of the crowd. Realizing, "It is he who can understand and grasp the Dhamma I preach most quickly," our Buddha, targeting that very leper—as if preaching a sermon specifically for him—systematically began that Dhamma sermon with the graduated discourse (*anupubbikathā*) in accordance with the Buddha's method of teaching.

The graduated discourse (*anupubbikathā*), pious devotees, means—now, in this instance, you devotees have sat down having undertaken the precepts, but those who came there were not like that; people of various statures and temperaments arrive. In order to prepare their minds, to prepare the mind in the manner required to understand a deep Dhamma, our Buddha employs a certain method of teaching, a pathway of teaching. It is described as: "*dāna-kathaṃ, sīla-kathaṃ, sagga-kathaṃ, kāmānaṃ ādīnavaṃ okāraṃ saṅkilesaṃ, nekkhamme ca ānisamsaṃ pakāsesi*." It is shown in this manner. "Dāna-kathā" (discourse on giving) means preaching first about giving as a good practice, a highly beneficial

practice, praising and showing the benefits of giving. Next, "sīla-kathā" (discourse on virtue) means declaring that just like the sacrifice of material goods in giving, the sacrifice made by restraining body and speech is also highly beneficial—thus declaring virtue (*sīla*). Next, in "sagga-kathā" (discourse on heaven), He declares that as a result of giving and observing precepts, one can be born in heaven, and relates accounts of those who were so born. In this way, when the listener's mind is focused on the pleasant qualities of heaven and is gladdened, our Buddha next points out the danger (*ādīnava*), the undesirable side, the evil side of the fivefold sensual pleasures—the sensual accomplishments enjoyed in the human world as well as in heaven. "Ādīnava, okāra"—these are very low things. The accomplishment of fivefold sense pleasures is something common even to animals, a base thing that cannot be considered noble—thus He declares: *okāraṃ*. Next, *saṅkilesaṃ*—how many people go astray and generate defilements due to these fivefold sensual pleasures. In this way, he shows: *ādīnavaṃ okāraṃ saṅkilesaṃ*. After their minds are directed to these aspects, our Buddha next declares instead *nekkhamme ca ānisamsaṃ*—the benefits of renunciation. Leaving the household life—becoming ordained—is a most valuable and noble practice. He then praises and commends these high virtues of separating oneself from fivefold sensual pleasures and departing from the household life, as a practice that helps one escape saṃsāra and realize the Nibbāna

In that manner, while our Buddha was delivering this graduated discourse and speaking about renunciation (*nekkhamma*), He was constantly watching how Suppabuddha's mind was working. Then our Buddha understood that the mind of Suppabuddha the leper was now prepared to hear the deep Dhamma—*kallacittaṃ, muducittaṃ* (a prepared mind, a soft mind), *vīnīvaraṇacittaṃ* (a mind free from hindrances, meaning that thoughts of sensual desire, ill-will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and doubt or indecision, which obstruct concentration, had been removed), and now the mind was highly—as in *udaggacittaṃ, pasannacittaṃ*—cheerful and clear, and Suppabuddha was in a state of waiting, as it were, for what was to be said next. At that moment, our Buddha preached that deep teaching called the Four Noble Truths, which is introduced to the world only by the Buddhas: suffering (*dukkha*), arising (*samudaya*), cessation (*nirodha*), and path (*magga*). He declared: "These five aggregates that we are grasping—form (*rūpa*), feeling (*vedanā*), perception (*saññā*), preparations (*saṅkhāra*), and consciousness (*viññāṇa*)—this entire saṃsāric existence is suffering (*dukkha*). The cause for this is craving / thirst (*taṇhā*). The calming of this craving / thirst—this burning—is extinguishment (*nirodha*). Nibbāna is the supreme bliss. The path to this is the Noble Eightfold Path: right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*), right intention

(*sammā-saṅkappa*), right speech (*sammā-vācā*), right action (*sammā-kammanta*), right livelihood (*sammā-ājīva*), right effort (*sammā-vāyāma*), right mindfulness (*sammā-sati*), and right concentration (*sammā-samādhi*)." Thus our Buddha declared the Four Noble Truths.

At that moment—the simile is given—just like a clean cloth that has been thoroughly washed takes dye perfectly, the prepared mind of Suppabuddha grasped this Four Noble Truths fully, and right on the seat where he was sitting, it is said: "*virajaṃ vītamalaṃ dhammacakkhuṃ udapādi*"—the stainless, dustless Dhamma-eye arose. He realized the fruit of stream-entry through the path-knowledge of stream-entry. Thus he attained that state. However, no one else knew that he had attained this; only our Buddha knew. At that moment, a massive change, an inner transformation, had occurred within that leper. So much so that Suppabuddha saw the Nibbāna. He saw extinguishment through the first path-knowledge—he became **diṭṭhadhammo** (one who has seen the Dhamma), **pattadhammo** (one who has reached the Dhamma). Likewise, doubts and hesitation regarding these things, regarding the Dhamma, were removed; doubts regarding the path to the Nibbāna were removed, and he entered into that practice. Furthermore, he attained a state of supreme confidence—boldness—in this Dispensation (**Sāsana**).

That first path-insight is a supramundane state. Having attained it, and when the Dhamma sermon concluded, this leper approached our Buddha and, praising Him, declared: "Excellent, venerable sir! Excellent, venerable sir! It is just as if—" and then he gives a simile—"Venerable sir, just as if one were to set upright what had been overturned, or to reveal what had been hidden, or to show the way to one who was lost, or to light, or hold up, an oil lamp in the dark so that those with eyes could see forms, in the same way the Blessed One has revealed the Dhamma to me in various ways. I go to the Blessed One for refuge, to the Dhamma for refuge, and to the Saṅgha for refuge. May the Blessed One accept me as a lay follower who has taken refuge from this day onwards for life." Having thus declared his exclamation of joy, he departed from that place.

Before going very far, before going a great distance, a fierce cow with a young calf gored Suppabuddha the leper and caused his death; he met his demise. The monks, seeing this incident, approached our Buddha and said, "Venerable Sir, Blessed One, that leper who was just inspired by the Blessed One with a Dhamma talk has died. Where has this person been reborn?" Then our Buddha declared, "Monks, this Suppabuddha was a wise man (**paṇḍita**). Suppabuddha was a wise man. He practiced according to the Dhamma I declared, and having broken three of the fetters that bind one to saṃsāra, he attained that noble state of stream-entry—a state more noble than even universal monarchy—whereby he will not fall

into the four lower realms and will take at most seven more births (*jāti*), seven more existences in saṃsāra." Thus our Buddha declared. Having attained that, now at this very moment of speaking, Suppabuddha the leper has been reborn in the Tāvātimsa heaven, and he outshines the other devas in his retinue and bodily complexion. Why? Because this Suppabuddha the leper, having approached this Dispensation, developed those virtues called faith (*saddhā*), virtue (*sīla*), learning (*suta*), generosity (*tyāga*), and wisdom (*paññā*). By listening to just that one sermon, Suppabuddha the leper acquired these five virtues: faith, virtue, learning (which is the gift of Dhamma), generosity (the quality of sacrifice), and wisdom (the capacity, the power of comprehension, to realize the Mind Stilled [Nibbāna]). He declared to the monks that Suppabuddha had acquired these five qualities. These indeed are called the "Noble Wealth" (*āriya-dhana*). Faith, virtue, learning, generosity, and wisdom are the five types of wealth belonging to the Noble Ones in this Dispensation. In this way, He declared it.

Then, from among those monks, one monk asked, "Blessed One, why did this Suppabuddha, who attained such a state, become a leper? Why was he so poor?" Why did such a fortunate person take birth in such a life? Next, our Buddha declared that story of the past. "Monks, in the past, in the distant past, this Suppabuddha the leper was the son of a treasurer (*setthi-putta*) in this very city of Rājagaha. One day, while this treasurer's son was going to the pleasure garden, leaving the city for the garden, Tagarasikhī, the Paccekabuddha, was entering the city for alms. Seeing the robes worn by this Paccekabuddha, this treasurer, intoxicated with pride, conceived a feeling of disgust. 'Who is this leper, wearing a garment of lepers?' thinking in such a derogatory manner, he spat in that direction, and then turning his left shoulder—to turn one's left shoulder and go was a sign of disrespect in ancient times, because 'paying respect' or circumambulation means turning to the right and walking—saying such disrespectful words and spitting, he went on to the garden." Then our Buddha declared the result of the unwholesome kamma (*akusala*) committed by that treasurer's son in that brief moment. It is mentioned in the Dhamma in terms of results: "*bahūni vassāni, bahūni vassasatāni, bahūni vassasahassāni, bahūni vassasatasahassāni niraye paccitvā*"—because of that evil deed committed in that brief moment, the treasurer Suppabuddha boiled in hell for many years, many hundreds of years, many thousands of years, many hundreds of thousands of years. Having boiled there and suffered grave pain, as the residue of that kamma—as the remaining portion—he took birth in this very city as a poor leper. Having thus declared the terrifying results of that evil deed, He uttered that verse of Dhamma which we took as our theme earlier:

Cakkhumā visamānīva

vijjamāne parakkame

paṇḍito jīvalokasmiṃ

pāpāni parivajjaye

— thus.

"Cakkhumā" means one who has eyes. "Visamāni" means uneven places—potholes, heights, thorny thickets; uneven places are called *visama*. Just as a person with eyes avoids uneven places on the ground—"Cakkhumā visamānīva, vijjamāne parakkame"—when there is the strength and effort (*parakkama*) to avoid those uneven places, those potholes and thorny thickets on the ground, when it is possible, if a person has eyes, if they can see, if they have the strength, they go avoiding those potholes and thorny thickets. That is what is expressed here. Showing this simile in this manner: "paṇḍito jīvalokasmiṃ, pāpāni parivajjaye"—likewise, the wise man—the true wise man, the true intelligent one—what does he do? In this living world, in this human world, he completely shuns those things called evil deeds. In that way, our Buddha uttered an advisory verse at that moment.

Therefore, let us reflect on the lessons we can extract for our lives from this verse and also from this story. Even from this present story of Suppabuddha the leper—from that itself, we can take many examples. Now, that Suppabuddha came to the place where our Buddha was preaching the Dhamma while searching for food, having seen a crowd and approaching them. "Perhaps here I can get something to eat," he thought. After drawing near, when he saw that this was a place where a sermon was being preached, he did not turn away with contempt, as some people with materialistic views in this day and age say, "Can we eat the Dhamma?" Instead, what did he do? "I too must listen to a bit of the Dhamma," he thought, and sat down. So, we can understand what arose in that person's mind at that moment: sacrifice, letting go. Now, you devotees also perform giving (*dāna*) and various meritorious distributions. In all of those, what is expected is this very sacrifice, this letting go. At that moment, he could have turned back to go search for food. Instead, he thought, "It does not matter if there is no food, I must listen to at least a bit of the Dhamma," and sat down. How great were the benefits of that sacrifice! He was able to attain that fruit of stream-entry, which is more noble than even universal monarchy. He was able to gain rebirth in heaven after death. This fruit of stream-entry, then, is the first step on the path to the Nibbāna which consists of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship. He attained that state, reducing his saṃsāric suffering (*dukkha*) to only seven lifetimes and destroying all the rest. He will never again go to the

four lower realms. Such a noble state was attained by Suppabuddha the leper through that sacrifice made in his mind.

Next, let us reflect on our Buddha's method of preaching the Dhamma. Our Buddha always preaches the Dhamma targeting the person whose mind is prepared, who has developed saṃsāric intelligence. From this, we can see that just because a person is sitting at the edge of the crowd, our Buddha does not marginalize them. Kings, royal princes, treasurers, extremely wealthy people, high-caste people, learned people, scholars—scholars of the world—might be present in that great crowd. Yet, our Buddha does not preach the Dhamma to them. It is to the person who is advanced in terms of saṃsāric intelligence. When we reflect on this, we can gain a very deep understanding. Our Buddha does not look at the world with the eyes of ordinary society. As we spoke of the condition of the lotus pond or water-lily pond, if we think about it, some flower buds might be hidden among the leaves. In the same way, some individuals might be born poor, destitute, as lepers, and with various other afflictions due to some grave evil deed committed in this world. But that person might have the strength to understand the noble Nibbāna. They might have practiced meditation in past saṃsāra. This can be a very great source of encouragement for someone to turn towards this Dhamma. Therefore, no one can be marginalized. Perhaps even in this very gathering, there might be those in such poor and destitute conditions who think, "We cannot go on this path of Dhamma; we cannot do these things by listening to sermons." But we can take an example from the story of Suppabuddha the leper. Perhaps, despite what they think of themselves, they too might be like those lotus flowers that bloom as soon as they receive the Dhamma-rays—the rays of the Buddha-sun. From this, we can take a valuable lesson.

Next, when our Buddha preached the Dhamma, the way Suppabuddha developed the Dhamma-eye—there it is mentioned: "**yaṃ kiñci samudayadhammaṃ sabban taṃ nirodhadhammaṃ**." That deep Dhamma—sometimes many who have learned Dependent Arising (**paṭicca-samuppāda**) from books make great efforts. Dependent Arising is a deep Dhamma. The fundamental principle of that deep Dhamma is what Suppabuddha the leper understood by listening to just that one sermon. What is its meaning? "Whatever is of the nature to arise, all that is of the nature to cease." That means he understood impermanence (**anicca**) thoroughly. That everything in the world is of the nature of arising and passing away. Here, "everything" means these five aggregates that we are grasping, called form (**rūpa**), feeling (**vedanā**), perception (**saññā**), preparations (**saṅkhāra**), and consciousness (**viññāṇa**). This is a heap of form. Here, "the aggregate of form" (**rūpakkhanda**) means a heap of form. We take it as a single form. By way of the perception of a being (**satta-saññā**), we take it as one.

Because of grasping it as "me" and "mine", worldly people try to beautify form, thinking "this is my form". When a feeling arises, they think "this is my feeling". Perception means recognition; they think "this is what I recognize". Preparations (*saṅkhāra*), intentions, expectations, and so forth—most of the time, these too are regarded as one. Next is consciousness (*viññāṇa*). When one says "my mind", one thinks of it as a single mind. These are a multiplicity. Indeed, although worldly people take them as one due to the perception of a being, within each of these, there lies a great heap. That is why in one place our Buddha has given similes—very deep similes. If one contemplates them, one can realize the Nibbāna through any single one of them.

This aggregate of form, this which is called form, is something made of the elements—earth, water, fire, and wind—which make up everything in this world. Next, our Buddha compares this to a lump of foam. When a stream is flowing, if a log is stuck somewhere, foam gradually accumulates there. If one looks at this lump of foam, one sees that it is changing at every moment. It arises and passes away, arises and passes away. In the same way, this cage of a body is made of the foam of milk, the foam of rice, and the foam of gruel. When food is taken throughout the day, this cage of a body is formed from the digestion of these things—this which we call the body. In this way, one can deeply contemplate a lump of foam.

Likewise, feeling (*vedanā*)—next, our Buddha showed that feeling is like a water bubble. When it rains heavily and water pours from the roof, water bubbles are formed, and in a single moment, in that very instant, they disappear; they do not last long. It is a very short time. When the rain falls, a beautiful little water bubble is formed. It bursts immediately. Feeling is just like that. Although we take it as one, it is like a flash—it is a multiplicity. That is the understanding.

Next, perception (*saññā*) means recognition. Our Buddha compares recognition to a mirage. You know what a mirage is—during the hot season, on a road or a plain, you can see what looks like flowing water in the distance. Because of the heat, something that trembles and wavers rises up like vapor, visible in the distance. That is called a mirage; from afar, one is deceived into thinking it is water. Thinking that there is water, one runs. As one runs and runs, the mirage recedes. Our Buddha describes this perception, this recognition, as such a thing. We say, "I recognized so-and-so; it is indeed that person and no other." Next, there might be a beautiful sight, perhaps a mirage of some lovely scenery. Thinking it is very beautiful, we might even take a photograph of it, and then, to see that scenery better, let us say we go there. Having gone there, that scenery is not there. When we turn back and look, perhaps that beautiful scenery is now on

this side. In this way, perception too is layer upon layer. When examined, there is nothing substantial to be grasped there.

Next, our preparations (*saṅkhāra*)—our intentions, expectations, thoughts, and all such things—these too, through a simile shown by our Buddha, are like a banana trunk. There is no pith, no substance, no core. There is only a heap of sheaths here, like in a banana trunk. It is not apparent that it is just a heap of sheaths. In that way, they are called preparations (*saṅkhāra*). The feelings, expectations, and so forth that we generate are also like that.

Next, consciousness (*viññāṇa*), which we refer to as "my mind". This too is not one. It is something that arises and passes away with extreme rapidity. Furthermore, the things shown by it—it presents various things to this mind, distinguishing one from another. But both this and that, both of these, are of the nature of arising and passing away. This is merely a heap of illusions. Our Buddha compares it to a magician, an illusionist, showing something through sleight of hand. He displays what does not exist as if it exists. In that way, various things are conjured up before our mind; there is a conjuring nature in it.

When this is said, the world does not understand it immediately. Nor do they wish to understand it. But for one who has contemplated deeply on the Three Characteristics of impermanence (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*) over a long period in saṃsāra, as they think about these things, they understand them deeper and deeper. That penetrative seeing is called wisdom (*paññā*), the true nature of the world. So, what is meant here is that Suppabuddha the leper understood, through that sermon of our Buddha, Dependent Arising—that everything in this world arises due to causes and conditions. "If anything is of the nature to arise, all that is of the nature to cease." Then, what assists in this is these five aggregates—these five aggregates of grasping (*pañcupādānakkhandha*) which we hold onto. We hold onto either form, feeling, perception, preparations, or consciousness, labeling them as "me" and "mine". It is when the true state of affairs—the reality—of each of these is understood, pious devotees, that one can realize the noble fruit of stream-entry and so forth through supramundane path-knowledge. Therefore, through this story, we can reflect on these things: we too must have practiced meditation to some extent in saṃsāra. We must make an effort to bring these back to the surface, thinking that they might be buried within us. In that way, we can learn many things from this present story.

Likewise, when we reflect on those five wealths—faith (*saddhā*), virtue (*sīla*), learning (*suta*), generosity (*tyāga*), and wisdom (*paññā*)—even through a single sermon, when someone listens to the Dhamma, they develop faith through

it. They develop faith in the Triple Gem. Next, when the benefits of virtue are declared, they develop virtue. Our Buddha shows it there as if they are undertaking the precepts. Indeed, during the Buddha's time, when our Buddha preached the Dhamma through the graduated discourse, they undertook them in their minds. Even without specifically asking for and undertaking the precepts, they would think in their minds, "How excellent a practice this is! From today, I shall protect this practice," and thus undertake it in their minds. That is it. They develop faith; they develop virtue. Next, "learning" (*suta*) means they retain this Dhamma well, bearing it in their minds. Next, as they understand the Dhamma, they realize that what truly must be done is the relinquishing of all these things—sacrifice (*tyāga*). It is through that sacrifice that the understanding called wisdom (*paññā*) arises. Generally, worldly knowledge is something gathered, something accumulated. To accumulate and obtain various titles, degrees, and so forth is what is expected from worldly knowledge. But, pious devotees, wisdom (*paññā*) is described as the power of penetrative seeing, the power of comprehension. It is the emergence of a Dhamma-eye, the emergence of a wisdom-eye, so that what is covered in the world becomes open and visible, or so that what is hidden is clearly seen by one's own eye. In this way, we can reflect on the five benefits of these virtuous qualities. That is the good side.

Next, when we reflect on that past account specifically declared here by our Buddha—which is closely connected to the verse—everyone can develop a great sense of dread. How many grave evil deeds might we commit unknowingly in saṃsāra—in this life? Pious devotees, in the past, that Suppabuddha was a treasurer's son, and by defiling his mind, polluting his mind for just a brief moment, and spitting, whom did he disrespect? Even though he wore a soiled robe, in the forests of that time, before Buddhas arise, a noble class of beings called Paccekabuddhas appear. They attain a certain state of Buddhahood through their own efforts. They cannot make others realize the Nibbāna but they are called "Paccekabuddhas"—private Buddhas. The Buddha, the Paccekabuddha, and the Arahant—these are the three greatest individuals in the world. Therefore, disrespecting the noble treasures of the world is an evil deed that brings extremely grave consequences. This is called the "offense of disparaging the Noble Ones" (*ariyūpavāda-kamma*). Disrespecting, abusing those who have attained the paths and fruits, such as Buddhas, Paccekabuddhas, Arahants, and Stream-enterers, is declared as the kamma of disparaging the Noble Ones. It is a grave evil deed. That is why he boiled in hell for many years, many hundreds of years, many thousands of years, many hundreds of thousands of years. When we reflect on this, these are the uneven places, the potholes of the world. We must protect ourselves from these, if we have eyes—the eye here means Right View

(*sammā-ditṭhi*), correct seeing. The value of someone having correct seeing is evident from this. Ordinary worldly people are blind. Our Buddha has declared: "*andhabhūto ayaṃ loko, tanukettha vipassati*"—"This entire world is blind; only a few here see with insight." Therefore, worldly people think they have eyes. To enhance this visible fleshly eye, they buy spectacles. But, pious devotees, our Buddha has declared that the world is blind. So, if one is to dispel blindness—blindness is dispelled to some extent when one understands good and bad, when one understands black and white, when one understands merit and demerit by listening to the Dhamma. Next, what is even deeper is what Suppabuddha the leper did. Understanding that noble fundamental principle of the Dhamma of Dependent Arising, understanding the Four Noble Truths, he developed the eye of wisdom—the Dhamma-eye. It is called the Dhamma-eye (*dhammacakkhu*). When that eye—the path-knowledge of stream-entry—arises, the doors to the four lower realms are closed forever. That is a massive gain, a gain so immense that it is beyond imagination. Therefore, in the ordinary world, one must protect oneself from these uneven places—from these potholes. In physical travel, falling into these and getting injured is a minor thing. But in this saṃsāra, if we fall by defiling our mind, corrupting our speech, and corrupting our actions, we will have to suffer the grave consequences for aeons. That is the lesson we can take from this past story.

Energy. That is such a thing. So, Suppabuddha the leper committed that mistake in his past life. But in this life, he did not make that mistake. Instead, as if he had learned his lesson well, without showing disrespect to the Dhamma at that moment, without saying "Can we eat the Dhamma?", he sat right there and began to listen to the Dhamma. Let us reflect on what kind of sacrifice that was.

Now, in this verse, our Buddha declares: "Cakkhumā visamānīva, vijjamāne parakkame." When effort/power (*parakkama*) exists—when hearing the word "parakkama" (power/effort), some might think this is something belonging only to people like King Parākramabāhu. But, pious devotees, our Buddha declares that whether poor or rich, high or low, learned or unlearned, within everyone there exist three types of energy. Our Buddha describes these three energies as *ārambha-dhātu* (element of initiating energy), *nikkama-dhātu* (element of exerting energy), and *parakkama-dhātu* (element of making an effort / overcoming energy). Here, "element" (*dhātu*) means that fundamental principle. "Ārambha-dhātu", pious devotees, means the energy we all have to start something new. Even a small child has it. Before parents arrive, small children make this and that—that is the initiating energy. The capacity to produce something new. There is such an *ārambha-dhātu*. Next, "nikkama-dhātu" means, having initiated something, we have the energy within us to carry it on continuously. Next, "parakkama-dhātu" means the victorious energy to crush,

conquer, and move forward against the obstacles and difficulties that arise while carrying it on. That too is present in this mental continuum. What was meant here by "vijjamāne parakkame" is that one can avoid these things with such effort. One can abandon these, avoid these. While there is such capacity, and when one's eyes can see, our Buddha asks, "Why do you do these things?"

Therefore, at that moment, what Suppabuddha the leper did was also a certain act of effort (*parakkama*). That is, he conquered his mind. The mind might say, "No, go find some food, there is no use listening to this." Perhaps he felt that way too; it is not mentioned in the story. Generally, if a poor person is hungry, they feel that way. Yet, this person sat right there, thinking "I must listen to a bit of Dhamma." That too is a victory. It was through that effort (*parakkama*) that Suppabuddha the leper attained that noble state of stream-entry, achieving a victory far greater than even universal monarchy. Now, as soon as we hear the word "parakkama" (power/effort/valor), we often think of battle—warfare. Our Buddha also made use of this word. For the Buddhist, too, there is a battle. Not only for those ordained, but even for the layperson, there is a battle. It is called the battle against Māra (the battle with death/defilements). There is also a battle-cry given by our Buddha for this battle against Māra—not only in this Dispensation, but in the Dispensation of all Buddhas. There is a battle-cry in a very beautiful verse:

Ārabhatha nikkamatha

yuñjatha buddhasāsane

dhunātha maccuno senaṃ

naḷāgāraṃva kuñjaro

— there is such a battle-cry. If we translate this into Sinhala:

"Arouse yourself! Exert yourself!

Commit yourself to the Buddha's Dispensation!

Deconstruct/Destroy the army of Death,

As an elephant crushes a reed-hut!"

There is such a battle-cry. So, when worldly people think of battle, of war, they think of defeating and killing other human beings, and winning thereby. That is what the world thinks of as effort (*parakkama*), valor, heroism, and greatness. But even if we think so, our Buddha, it seems, did not think that way. Because our Buddha has declared in the Dhammapada:

"Yo sahaṣṣaṃ sahaṣṣena*

saṅgāme mānuse jine

ekañca jeyya attānaṃ

sa ve saṅgāmajuttamo

— thus."

Though a brave and heroic warrior goes to battle and defeats a million men—this one warrior—yet he defeats a million enemies. Think of what a feat that is! One person defeating a million enemies. Our Buddha next shows something greater than that: "ekañca jeyya attānaṃ, sa ve saṅgāmajuttamo"—but to conquer this single "self" which one thinks of as "myself". Conquering oneself—this is called "self-conquest" (*ātma-vijaya*). "Conquering oneself" means through giving, virtue, and meditation; by cultivating virtue, concentration, and wisdom; by developing those virtuous qualities—the qualities of the Dispensation—practicing meditation, and thereby penetrating the noble paths and fruits of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship, to realize the noble Dhamma of the Nibbāna. It is to conquer the entirety of saṃsāric suffering (*dukkha*) and the death-dealer of defilements. Now, our Buddha too waged that battle against Māra and is declared to have conquered the army of Māra. This army of Māra resides in this mind. Ultimately, in a deep sense, what is declared here is an army of Māra arising in the mind. Therefore, here, our Buddha made use of the concept of "war" and "battle" to bring out the power of effort—initiating energy, exerting energy, and overcoming energy—within man. Now, you are preparing to perform some feat. For that, you get well equipped, dressed in matching attire, armed with weapons, and ready. Next, you go forward prepared. As you go forward, there are enemies. Completely attacking those enemies, crushing them, you win. That is what effort (*parakkama*) is. Thus: *ārambha-dhātu, nikkama-dhātu, parakkama-dhātu*. Based on these three energies, we conquer even the difficulties that come in our day-to-day lives.

If that is so, then our Buddha shows a victory far greater than that—conquering oneself, self-conquest. We must reflect according to that concept of self-conquest: every victory we win in this world ultimately becomes a defeat when viewed from the perspective of the next life. If a possessor of higher knowledges (*abhiññā-lābhī*), a Buddha, were to declare where some of these conquerors go and are reborn, what a sense of urgency and dismay (*saṃvega*) would arise! Those whom we think of as heroic and brave are sometimes reborn in very sorrowful places after death. This is the nature of the world, the saṃsāric condition. But our Buddha has shown us the truth of these things, even if we do not like it.

Therefore, if one is a wise person, if one has eyes, if one has that correct seeing called Right View (*sammā-ditṭhi*), one must accept the word of the Buddha. Thus, "sa ve saṅgāmajuttamo"—"saṅgāmajī" means the one who has won the battle. The path to that is, in this world, to shun those evil deeds, to remove unwholesome states, and to constantly incline the mind towards the wholesome—by mind, body, and speech—protecting the three doors of mind, body, and speech. Now, we protect our fort, if we have one, from enemies. Without letting enemies enter, we guard it day and night. In the same way, the meditator, the practitioner, or the one who hopes for the Nibbāna protects their three doors of mind, body, and speech while cultivating those qualities of virtue, concentration, and wisdom. When we reflect even deeper, there are six doors: the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind. In this way, by guarding these doors, one guards the fort. Next, instead, one cultivates the good side—that virtue, the quality of concentration. Through concentration, one unifies the mind. Removing the scattered nature of the mind, one then generates the penetrative power of wisdom (*paññā*) in one's mental continuum, and it is through that wisdom that one realizes the Nibbāna and conquers all saṃsāric suffering (*dukkha*).

Therefore, one must make an effort to bring out this power of effort (*parakkama*)—for the battle against Māra that must be waged for this. We must start this from where we are. In day-to-day life, there are various obstacles to these things. In day-to-day life—now, many people live attached and deeply immersed in life, just like those lotus buds and water-lily buds submerged in water. But our Buddha has declared that no one should defile their mind based on the social level they find themselves in externally. If they have made a beginning, they might obtain those states much faster than they expected. Suppabuddha the leper would not have even thought, when he went there, that he would receive such a noble state. Yet, he obtained it. In that way. What assists in that is "the perception of capability" (*haki-saññā*). Pious devotees, "the perception of capability" means the understanding that "I can do this". Now, we know that when we need to roll something over or remove it, as soon as we think "I cannot do it", we are defeated right there. We must make at least an intentional effort. Having generated the effort, thinking "I must do this", we next think "I can do this". That is called "the perception of capability". It is by putting forward "the perception of capability" in this manner that we must tread this path of Dhamma.

Our Buddha has assured us that we can tread this path. Sometimes, like a mother persuading her child to drink a bitter medicine, our Buddha declares to the monks—even if He declares it to the monks, He is declaring it to the entire world: "Monks, these unwholesome states (*akusala*) can be abandoned, can be eliminated. It is possible to be freed from them. It is possible to destroy them. In the same way, wholesome states (*kusala*) can be developed. Monks, if it were

not possible to destroy these unwholesome states, I would not tell you to do so. It is because it is possible to destroy unwholesome states that I tell you to do so, monks." In this way, He sometimes declares it with persuasion. At other times, to increase that effort, He says, "Monks, if you abandon just two things, I guarantee that you will become Non-returners (*Anāgāmi*): abandon greed (*lobha*) and hatred (*dosa*)." Because of this persuasive nature, sometimes instead of saying "our Buddha", we call Him "our Buddha-Mother" or "our Deathless-Mother" (*Amā-mæṇi*). It is because of that great compassionate quality.

Therefore, according to that Dhamma of our Buddha, we must reflect on our own lives. By listening to this story, what we expect is—this Dhamma story is not a fabricated story, a novel, or a short story. These are true events. The way those individuals met our Buddha during the Buddha's time and attained those noble states. These are good examples and lessons for us. Through these, we must understand that this energy can exist within us too, and we must make an effort to bring it out. Now, on this occasion too, you devotees undertook a valuable virtue called the Eight Precepts with Livelihood as the Eighth (*ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla*). One must reflect on each of these virtuous practices. What do we do through these? What do we do by undertaking these precepts? When saying "samādiyāmi", I make a determination that I abstain from taking life, that is, from killing animals and so forth. In protecting that determination too, one can gain an understanding of those states called *ārambha-dhātu*, *nikkama-dhātu*, and *parakkama-dhātu*. I determined that I will not kill animals. But due to various reasons—for whatever reason—either for food, or for entertainment, or due to the instigation of others, or to obtain more wealth, or to satisfy hatred, thoughts to kill animals arise. A thought comes. But as soon as that thought comes, next, on this path of Dhamma, in the manner of *ārambha-dhātu*, *nikkama-dhātu*, *parakkama-dhātu*, one must recollect this virtuous practice. "It is not good to do that. There are such consequences. I have undertaken the Five Precepts; I have undertaken the Precepts with Livelihood as the Eighth. This is one practice of this virtue. I myself have accepted this and promised to practice it," and thus one makes an effort to protect it. Making such an effort, at some point, one completely pushes away that unwholesome thought from the mind. Sometimes, it is difficult to push it away like that. At times, one even has to fight with it. "It doesn't matter—even if there are consequences, let us do this," the mind says. "It cannot be helped at this moment. This is 'timely', 'appropriate'. According to the moment, we must do this"—in this way, those unwholesome states arise from deep within the mind. That is indeed Māra standing behind and saying, "Do it, do it." It is there that one must next employ faith. Faith in the Triple Gem, deep faith, thinking, "The Buddha's word is indeed true." Reflecting in that way, and thinking, "No, I shall not break this," and thus firmly reflecting

and driving away the unwholesome thoughts—that indeed is effort (*parakkama*). It is the same regarding theft, sexual misconduct, lying, harsh speech, and those unwholesome states, and ultimately, those wrong livelihoods (*micchā-ājīva*)—for many, carrying on this livelihood seems impossible without doing them. But even regarding those, one must make an effort to see if it is impossible. Trading in weapons, trading in poisons, trading in intoxicants, breeding animals for slaughter, trading in meat—regarding such things, regarding life, we must reflect on whether we cannot conquer them. Because there is a terrifying side of consequences to these.

In the Buddha's Dispensation, there was the great Venerable Moggallāna. Venerable Moggallāna had a special power—his power of higher knowledges (*abhiññā*). Because of that, and because of his noble parami power, he would go to the heavens and ask the devas about the merit that helped them obtain those states. Next, he would go to the hells and ask the beings in hell about the cause for their suffering—what evil deeds they had committed. Through that, he declared to the world: "These are the terrifying consequences; do not do these things because of this." If we have to pay for these in saṃsāric time for a long period, there is no use in performing these "feats" in a single life. Therefore, we must make a special effort to be freed from saṃsāra. This terrifying nature of the mind—it is unpredictable when it will incline towards evil. Therefore, "protecting" this mind is what is called meditation. To destroy these promptings of the mind, these things the mind says, we must systematically practice some meditation. We must make an effort to calm the mind. Now, it was when the mind of Suppabuddha the leper was calmed and clear that our Buddha declared that deep Dhamma. In that way, one must make an effort to concentrate one's mind. In day-to-day life, practicing "recollection of the Buddha" (*buddhānussati*)—by constantly reflecting on the qualities of the Buddha—loving-kindness meditation (*mettā-bhāvanā*), also meditation on foulness (*asubha-bhāvanā*), and mindfulness of death (*maraṇasati*)—you devotees know these are called the Four Guardian Meditations. By constantly practicing such things, one must keep the mind, which runs to the world, within a deep wholesome thought, and make an effort to unify the mind.

Likewise, there is a great power in that unified mind. When this flowing water is collected in a reservoir, and taken through certain pipes, or taken from mountains through tunnels, and when this water is brought through a single pipe, what is it used for? To spin an iron wheel. This flowing water has enough power to spin an iron wheel. But there is a special technique to develop this. In the same way, this mind, this scattered mind—one must concentrate it. Having concentrated it, one must next make an effort to look at the true nature of the world with that concentrated mind. Suppabuddha the leper must have used the

consequences of that evil deed to develop disillusionment regarding these five aggregates. Now, if someone is beautiful and strong, if they are proud of their body, it is difficult for them to understand that this form (*rūpa*), is suffering (*dukkha*), that it is a heap of diseases. Our Buddha calls this cage of a body "a nest of diseases" (*roga-nīlaṃ*), "a fragile framework". Our Buddha declares it is a nest of diseases that can break apart. At other times, it is declared in the Dhamma as "a great wound with nine openings" (*navadvāro mahāvaṇo*). Hearing these, some might even get angry. "Why did our Buddha disparage this?" Those who got angry in this way are mentioned in stories like that of Māgandiyā. But the one who has faith in our Buddha reflects, "This is true." And that can be understood by someone who has physical weakness. No one else needs to say it. Everyone disgusts this body if it is a leper. Then, when he reached that state, Suppabuddha the leper, like a "blessing in disguise", made use of the consequences of that evil deed. In that way, we must reflect that to travel on this path of the Nibbāna we should not think of realizing the Nibbāna after this country overflows with milk and honey, obtaining a prosperous life, and becoming wealthy. If we have some shortcomings—whether in wealth, or in body, or through diseases and afflictions—we must use that very thing to bring out that energy called *ārambha-dhātu, nikkama-dhātu, parakkama-dhātu*. Why? Most of the time, we learn the lesson from the consequences themselves. It is only after the teacher beats us that the "sum" is solved correctly. In that way, although we have suffered endless afflictions from Māra in this disobedient saṃsāra, we did not learn the lesson from them. Our Buddha has shown us the way to learn that lesson.

Therefore, you devotees should be glad now that the time was spent to shape our lives by making use of the Dhamma preached by our Buddha. On this occasion, you made a determination to observe a valuable virtue called the Eight Precepts with Livelihood as the Eighth. Likewise, during the time of listening to the Dhamma, we must think that we made an effort to cultivate five faculties (*indriya*), five powers (*bala*), which will assist us in realizing the Nibbāna on some day. It is by bringing out the five faculties of faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom (*saddhā, viriya, sati, samādhi, paññā*) that one realizes the Nibbāna. Faith is a faculty. "Faculty" (*indriya*) means a state of dominance, a dominant state in one's mental continuum. One must adorn this—faith. Next, one must bring out energy—*viriya*. One must turn the faculty of energy into a dominant state. Next, mindfulness (*sati*)—mindfulness, next concentration (*samādhi*), next wisdom (*paññā*)—this helps to cultivate, to generate these faculty-Dhammas. If one has generated those faculties, they become "powers" (*bala*) for that person: the power of faith (*saddhā-bala*), power of energy (*viriya-bala*), power of mindfulness (*sati-bala*), power of

concentration (*samādhi-bala*), power of wisdom (*paññā-bala*). At this moment, you engaged in listening to the Dhamma in a way that serves as a powerful supportive condition (*upanissaya*) to generate them. You must reflect that many wholesome thoughts were deposited in our mental continuum moment by moment. From them, many saṃsāric benefits will flow. There is no need to speak of that separately. But more than all of that, we must reflect on the nature of suffering (*dukkha*) in saṃsāra, which our Buddha has declared on countless occasions. Therefore, in this rare era of a Buddha's appearance, we must use all the wholesome wealth we can obtain—we must "invest" these—for the Nibbāna for the peace of the Nibbāna to bring an end to this saṃsāric suffering (*dukkha*).

Reflecting in this way, may we, by the power of this mass of merit accumulated through listening to the Dhamma and undertaking the precepts for this long, be able in this very life, if possible, like Suppabuddha the leper, through the penetration of the paths and fruits of Stream-entry and so forth, to end all saṃsāric suffering (*dukkha*) of birth (*jāti*), aging (*jarā*), sickness, and death (*maraṇa*) in the noble, deathless Nibbāna. Thus you must make an aspiration. Likewise, if there are any sāsana-protecting deities, or deities presiding over this sacred place, who are expecting merits, expecting the Nibbāna may they all rejoice in this mass of merit accumulated by us through preaching and listening to the Dhamma. Having rejoiced, may they realize the noble, deathless Nibbāna through a path of awakening of their aspiration. Likewise, not only our relatives who have passed away and gone to the next world, but all beings from Avīci to Akaniṭṭha who desire merit and desire the Nibbāna may they all rejoice in this mass of merit of ours, be freed from all saṃsāric suffering (*dukkha*) of birth, aging, sickness, and death, and find peace in the noble, deathless, unconditioned (*asaṅkhata*), supreme, and stilled mind of Nibbāna. Reflecting thus, share the merits by reciting these verses:

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”